

There are several advantages of a branded PC over an assembled one. However, with so many brands out there, and so many different needs, it can be hard to choose. But we're here to help!

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What better way to start off the year than by getting yourself a new PC? We've done all the hard work for you! What follows is a comparison test to help you choose from amongst many of the branded models available.

As you probably know, the first thing you've got to decide on when getting a new PC is whether

it's going to be Intel-based or AMD-based. Last year saw some heady battles between the two, and AMD leads as of right now. This translates into a big change in the PC market: a few years ago, thinking about an AMD system for your home was sort of a weird idea. You had to have "Intel Inside"! Nothing could be further from the truth today, and sporting the AMD 64 sticker on your PC bonnet is the in thing.

The Indian PC market is quite different from those abroad. Here, assembled PCs in the desktop segment still have a stronghold on the consumer's psyche, given the price difference vis-à-vis branded PCs. Branded PCs are now trying to break out of the "expensive" mould. While some brands such as HP, HCL and Acer have been around in the country for quite some time, there are several new entrants, such as Krypton.

Here's where our comparison tests come in. We've compared some of the biggest brands in the country head-to-head—this comparison therefore gives us an opportunity to tell you about what best PC brands are available in the Indian market.

We won't say our comparison tests are the be-all and end-all of the matter, but they will definitely give you a fair idea of price to performance ratios and more. As always, we advise you to use this comparison just as a guide when making your purchase decision.

We can hear you saying, "Why not assembled?" While assembled PCs may be cheaper, there are issues such as customer support and pirated software. These are usually not talked about when you make your purchase. With a branded PC, on the other hand, you're assured of legal software with warranties, and generally, of good service. Of course, you've got to read the fine print!

We divided the PCs we received for our tests into three segments—those below Rs 25,000, those above that cut-off, and Media Center PCs. We advise you not to decide right at this point how much you want to spend—first take a look at what's on offer!